

“... statues that foreknow the future and predict it by lots, by prophecy, by dreams ... that make people ill and cure them.”

UNKNOWN AUTHOR ON *STOICHEIOSIS*, THE *ASCLEPIUS*, 3RD CENTURY CE

be an occult practice. Nevertheless, the court used astrologers for guidance. Famously, the 11th-century scholar Symeon Seth's reading of the stars led him to correctly predict the death of Robert of Sicily who conquered Byzantine Italy. Seth sealed these words in an envelope beforehand: “A great enemy from the West who has stirred up many things will suddenly die.”

As late as the 12th century, Byzantine princess, scholar, physician, and author Anna Komnene included astrological references in her historical work the *Alexiad*, but the net was closing in. In the same century the historian Niketas Choniates condemned Emperor Manuel I for believing in reading the stars as if it was the word of God, and railed against “pestilential astrologers.”

Second only to astrology was lecanomancy (dish-divining). This involved looking for patterns in a dish of water, or observing the ripples created by a stone dropped into it. The idea came from ancient Babylonia, but it was popular in Byzantium, and the Byzantine court often used a lecanomancer. There were a host of other divining methods, most taken extremely seriously. These included the art of chremetismomancy (interpreting horses' neighs);

► Imperial dream

Basil I, one of Byzantium's greatest emperors, was born a peasant in Macedonia, but his mother dreamed that he would one day wear the crown. Her prophecy came true, as illustrated in this manuscript by 11th-century author-scholar John Skylitzes.

palomancy (based on inadvertent bodily twitches); and hepatoscopy (reading omens in animal livers). Strangest of all were the interpretations of *engastrimythoi* (literally, belly speakers), mediums who gave predictions in odd voices while in a state of trance and possession.

Interpreting dreams

Byzantine dream manuals were called *Oneirocritica*, after the 2nd-century book of that name by Greek scholar Artemidorus. Interpreting dreams was highly popular and mostly considered legitimate since, it was argued, the dreams were sent by God. Indeed many dream manuals were written by church patriarchs such as Nicephorus and Germanus. A 10th-century text on preparations for an imperial trip recommended packing a dream manual as standard equipment.

▲ Divining through water

This 10th-century glass Byzantine bowl was made for lecanomancy (the interpretation of water patterns). It is tiny—just 6½ in (17 cm) tall—perfect for concentrating the diviner's mind.

